

Stenella longirostris

Spinner dolphin



Location Tropical waters worldwide

Length 4¼–9 ft (1.3–2.8 m)

Weight Up to 175 lb (80 kg)

Social unit Group

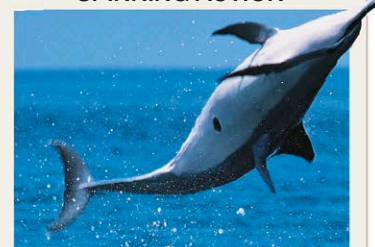
Status Data deficient

of sharp teeth in each of the upper and lower jaws, except the smallest of the subspecies, which has only 40–52 pairs. Coloration is black or dark gray, fading to a pale or white underside, with black edging to the eyes and lips, although this is very variable. The spinner dolphin dives deep to eat midwater fish and squid. It forms massive schools of hundreds

or thousands, which often associate with other cetaceans, and even with predatory fish such as tuna—although the reason for this is not clear.

BODY FORM

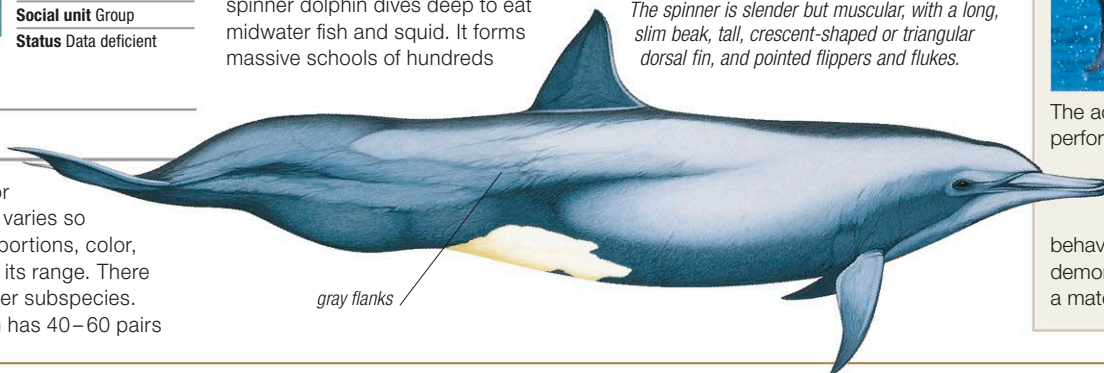
The spinner is slender but muscular, with a long, slim beak, tall, crescent-shaped or triangular dorsal fin, and pointed flippers and flukes.

SPINNING ACTION

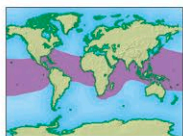
The acrobatic spinner dolphin performs high leaps when it twists in the air or spins on its vertical axis several times. The purpose of this behaviour is unclear. It may be to demonstrate fitness and/or attract a mate, or to dislodge parasites.



No other dolphin, or possibly cetacean, varies so greatly in body proportions, color, and pattern across its range. There are at least 4 spinner subspecies. The spinner dolphin has 40–60 pairs

*Stenella attenuata*

Pantropical spotted dolphin



Location Tropical and temperate waters worldwide

Length 5¼–8½ ft (1.6–2.6 m)

Weight Up to 260 lb (120 kg)

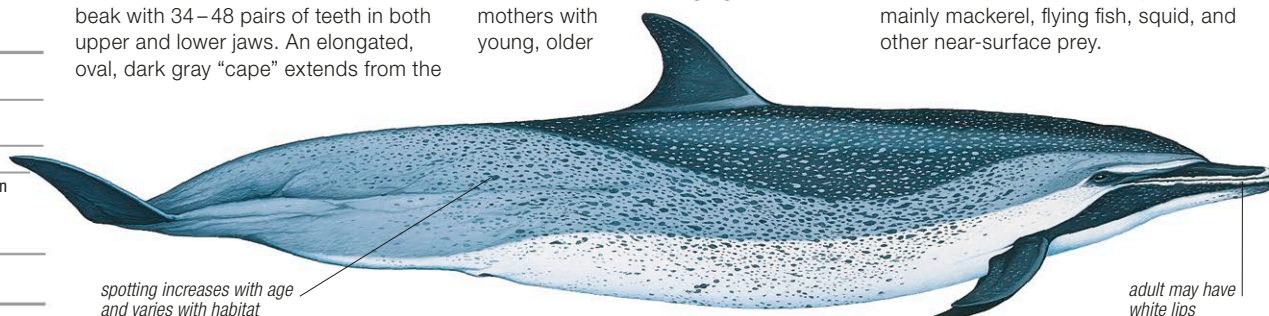
Social unit Group

Status Least concern

One of the commonest cetaceans, this dolphin is usually found in waters warmer than 72°F (22°C). It has a slender, streamlined body and slim beak with 34–48 pairs of teeth in both upper and lower jaws. An elongated, oval, dark gray “cape” extends from the

forehead to just behind the dorsal fin. The flanks are lighter gray and the underside is pale. Large superpods of thousands are often segregated into mothers with young, older

juveniles, and other subgroups. These all associate with other cetaceans, especially spinner dolphins and tuna fish. Pantropical spotted dolphins eat mainly mackerel, flying fish, squid, and other near-surface prey.

*Stenella frontalis*

Atlantic spotted dolphin



Location Atlantic

Length 5½–7½ ft (1.7–2.3 m)

Weight 240–315 lb (110–143 kg)

Social unit Variable

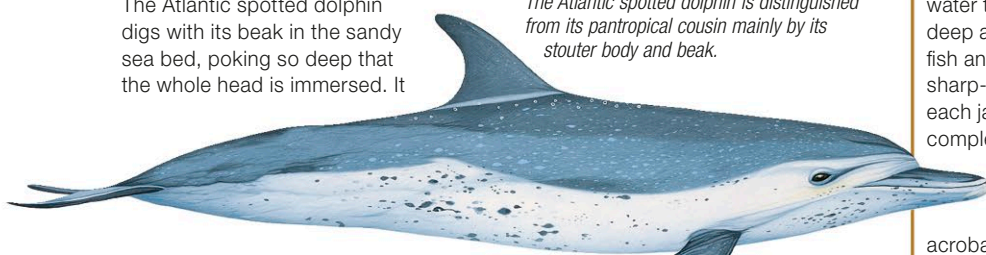
Status Data deficient

also uses various techniques to catch fish, squid, and other prey from surface and midwaters. It has 32–42 pairs of teeth in the upper jaw and the same in the lower jaw. The Atlantic spotted dolphin forms schools of up to 15 individuals near coasts, but these may gather into larger groups to follow seasonal food. Like its pantropical relative (above), the newborn calf lacks spots. These develop with age, starting on the belly and extending to the sides and back over several years.

STOUTER SPECIES

The Atlantic spotted dolphin is distinguished from its pantropical cousin mainly by its stouter body and beak.

The Atlantic spotted dolphin digs with its beak in the sandy sea bed, poking so deep that the whole head is immersed. It

**SPOT THE HABITAT**

In several spotted dolphin species, including the Atlantic and pantropical, the dark patches and flecks increase in extent with age but may also vary with habitat. These marks are generally less prominent in oceanic groups. In populations that stay near coasts, the spots may be so extensive as to obscure the background color.

*Stenella coeruleoalba*

Striped dolphin



Location Tropical and temperate waters worldwide

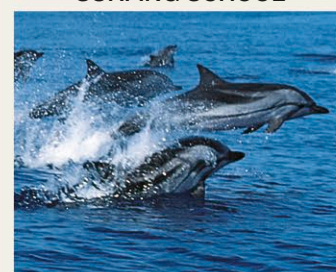
Length 7–8½ ft (2.2–2.6 m)

Weight 288–340 lb (131–156 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern

This species lives in areas of changeable water temperature and may dive as deep as 655 ft (200 m) to seize small fish and squid, using the 40–55 sharp-pointed pairs of teeth present in each jaw. It derives its name from the complex pattern of black and gray stripes along its back and flanks. This active dolphin is capable of a wide variety of acrobatic leaps and spins. Although it is relatively common, its numbers have declined in recent years. In particular, infection by a morbilli virus drastically reduced Mediterranean populations in the early 1990s.

SURFING SCHOOL

Schools of 50–500 striped dolphins race across the ocean and may gather in thousands, leaping high and whistling to keep in contact. They ride pressure waves just in front of migrating great whales, and the man-made equivalent—ship bow waves, especially in Mediterranean and Atlantic waters.

COLORATION

The thin black and wider gray stripes branch or fork and overlay a dark, blue-gray back, blue-gray sides, and pale cream or pink underside. It has a black beak and eye patches.

